CHAPTER 3

ELECTION AND REPRESENTATION

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Evaluate First Past the Post and Proportional Representation electoral systems, reserved constituencies, independent Election Commission, and vital electoral reforms in India.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **First Past the Post Electoral Mechanism:** Under FPTP, the country is divided into single-member constituencies; the candidate who secures the highest number of votes in a constituency is declared elected, even without securing an absolute majority.

• **Proportional Representation System:** PR allocates legislative seats in proportion to the percentage of popular votes polled by political parties; in India, the Single Transferable Vote (STV) variant is used for Rajya Sabha, President, and Vice-President elections.

• **Reserved Constituencies and Affirmative Representation:** To overcome historical exclusion, Articles 330 and 332 mandate reserved seats for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes in Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabhas based on population proportion determined by the Delimitation Commission.

• **Independent Election Commission of India:** Article 324 establishes an autonomous, multi-member Election Commission entrusted with superintendence, direction, and conduct of elections, empowered to enforce the Model Code of Conduct.

ESSENTIAL FORMULAS & GOVERNING EQUATIONS

$$\text{FPTP Mandate} \Leftrightarrow \text{Candidate Votes} > \max(\text{Opponent Votes}) \Rightarrow \text{Seat Victory}$$

Plurality principle where highest vote tally secures the constituency seat

$$\text{Election Quota} = \left[\frac{\text{Total Valid Votes Polled}}{\text{Number of Seats to Fill} + 1}\right] + 1$$

Droop quota formula determining victory threshold in Indian Rajya Sabha elections

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** In the First Past the Post system, a candidate does not need an absolute majority (50 percent plus one vote); having a simple plurality over all other candidates is sufficient to win.

• **Alert:** Elections to the Rajya Sabha and State Legislative Councils use Proportional Representation by Single Transferable Vote, not First Past the Post.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. What is meant by the First Past the Post (FPTP) electoral system? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Single-Member Constituencies:** The entire country or state is divided into territorial single-member constituencies where each voter casts one vote. **[1 Mark]**

• **Plurality Principle:** The candidate who obtains more votes than any other competitor in the constituency is declared elected, without requiring an absolute majority. **[1 Mark]**

2. Why did the framers of the Indian Constitution choose the FPTP system over Proportional Representation for general elections? [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Simplicity for Voters:** The system is remarkably simple to understand for common voters in a vast and newly literate electorate. **[1 Mark]**

• **Clear Voter Choice:** Voters choose specific local representatives rather than abstract party lists, ensuring a direct geographic bond between citizens and their representative. **[1 Mark]**

• **Government Stability:** FPTP generally awards the winning party more seats than its vote share, facilitating stable parliamentary majorities and effective governance. **[1 Mark]**

3. Differentiate between First Past the Post and Proportional Representation systems across four structural features. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **1. Constituency Division:** In FPTP, the country is divided into small single-member constituencies; in PR, large multi-member constituencies or the entire country acts as one constituency. **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Voting Preference:** In FPTP, the voter votes directly for a specific candidate; in PR, the voter usually votes for a political party or ranks candidate preferences. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Seat Allocation:** In FPTP, a party may secure a higher proportion of seats than its vote percentage; in PR, seats are allocated in direct proportion to votes polled. **[1 Mark]**

• **4. Victory Threshold:** In FPTP, a simple plurality is sufficient to win; in PR, a candidate must reach a predetermined electoral quota or party threshold. **[1 Mark]**

4. Explain the constitutional powers and independent functions of the Election Commission of India under Article 324. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Superintendence and Control:** Exercises complete superintendence, direction, and control over elections to Parliament, State Legislatures, President, and Vice-President. **[1 Mark]**

• **Voter Registration:** Prepares and updates comprehensive electoral rolls to ensure no eligible adult citizen is disenfranchised. **[1 Mark]**

• **Election Administration:** Determines election schedules, notifies constituencies, accepts nominations, scrutinizes papers, and assigns official party symbols. **[1 Mark]**

• **Model Code Enforcement:** Enforces the Model Code of Conduct to ensure free and fair campaigning, preventing ruling parties from misusing official machinery. **[1 Mark]**

5. Discuss the rationale, constitutional provisions, and social impact of reserved constituencies in the Indian parliamentary democracy. **[Score: 5 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Historical Exclusion Context:** In an open plurality contest, deeply entrenched caste hierarchies could prevent oppressed social groups from winning legislative representation. **[1 Mark]**

• **Constitutional Mandate:** Articles 330 and 332 provide reserved seats for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies. **[1 Mark]**

• **Mechanism of Representation:** In a reserved constituency, all registered adults vote, but only candidates belonging to the designated SC or ST community can contest. **[1 Mark]**

• **Delimitation Role:** The independent Delimitation Commission demarcates boundaries and selects constituencies with high concentrations of SC or ST populations. **[1 Mark]**

• **Social Integration:** It guarantees institutional presence and voice for marginalized groups in the highest policymaking bodies of the republic. **[1 Mark]**

6. Identify the major challenges confronting the electoral process in India and propose four critical electoral reforms to strengthen democratic integrity. **[Score: 6 Marks]**

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Major Challenge 1 (Money Power):** Excessive election expenditure by wealthy candidates and corporate donations undermines fair competition and distorts voter choices. **[1 Mark]**

• **Major Challenge 2 (Criminalization of Politics):** Candidates facing severe criminal charges frequently enter legislative chambers, weakening the rule of law. **[1 Mark]**

• **Reform 1 (State Funding):** Introduce state funding of elections to curb unregulated private wealth and provide a fair baseline for independent and grassroots candidates. **[1 Mark]**

• **Reform 2 (Barring Criminal Offenders):** Enact strict statutory disqualification barring persons facing framed charges in heinous crimes from contesting elections. **[1 Mark]**

• **Reform 3 (Internal Party Democracy):** Legally mandate transparent intra-party elections and open accounts audits for all registered political parties. **[1 Mark]**

• **Reform 4 (Hybrid PR Elements):** Consider incorporating proportional elements to align party seat shares more closely with popular vote percentages. **[1 Mark]**